



ENTER THE REVOLUTIONARY

If 2009 was the year of those who spurred revivals in their sports, 2010 needs those willing to support these soloists

By Sharda Ugra

It was their time. Like they owned the entire year. The badminton player who rations her time-off in careful coffee spoons but in 2009, devoured the distance between herself and the world's best with an appetite that only she can feel.

The tennis player who liked to keep his hair long but all arguments against him short, as he snatched the title of India's No.1 singles player as if it were a backstage pass to a concert

by his beloved Dave Matthews Band.

The cricketer whose flirty wrists and sparkling feet were always well known but who used the year to show us the vein of iron in his soul and long-range vision of his mind.

A pair of boxers who belong to two ends of Bata shoe sizes but whose blood seems to pound with the same beat when they step into the ring.

And a golfer who came through from a town known mostly for railway coaches but whose speed of progress this year matched the Shinkansen.

But to merely say that this was their time is not enough. Sure, they had a good 2009, but what is even more true is that this is their age. The age of the Indian athlete's new avatar rising in a very uncommon millennium.

Now it doesn't matter if your understanding of the word avatar belongs to

Hindu mythology, Hollywood sci-fi or computer gaming. What is central in this storyline is more about what the Indian athletes have done because it is what they are all about. The promise of their possibility is actually a stretch of India's sporting standards.

Saina Nehwal, 19, became the youngest woman, ever, to win one of her sport's elite Super Series event and the first Indian in a long time to break into the top 10 in world badminton.

Somdev Devvarman, 24, gave the folks in Chennai a chance to root for a local hero in the final of the ATP Tour event where singles had always belonged to outsiders. Then nine months later, he clawed

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(Clockwise from top)
The Indian cricket team;
Saina Nehwal;
Yuki Bhambhani;
Somdev Devvarman